



for Lakshadweep and other

statement on “prioritising national interest over business”. “We have suspended Maldives flight bookings in support of the government, impacting 240,000 annual bookings made through our platform. In fact, bookings surged by approximately 40 per cent last year as compared with the previous year,” says Prashant Pitti, Co-founder of EaseMyTrip.

Many travel portals have introduced Lakshadweep as one of their premium destination options.

“The PM’s initiative to inspire Indians to explore our country’s less explored or hidden gem, Lakshadweep, and its pristine islands has successfully garnered significant attention. The island has become the most searched destination across the world today, and our search data indicates a surge of almost 200 per cent on our portal for Lakshad-

THE BACKLASH

▶ **Maldivian politician Zahid Rameez triggered a controversy by mocking Lakshadweep on January 5**

▶ **It led to social media outburst with #BoycottMaldives trending in India**

▶ **Travel companies say it has sparked a big shift in Indians’ holiday plans to the island nation**

▶ **Indians topped the list of tourists to the Maldives in 2023, accounting for 11 per cent of visitors**

weep cruise sailings,” says Daniel D’Souza, President and Country Head-Holidays, SOTC Travel.

MakeMyTrip (MMT), too, has seen a similar surge in on-platform searches for Lakshadweep since the Prime Minister’s visit. “We have observed a 3,400 per cent increase in on-platform searches for Lakshadweep... This interest in Indian beaches has inspired us to launch a ‘Beaches of India’ campaign on the platform with offers and discounts...” MMT said in a statement.

The Indian government has remained tight-lipped about its next steps, even though the Ministry of External Affairs summoned Maldives High Commissioner Ibrahim Shaheeb. The Government of the Maldives suspended three deputy cabinet ministers—Abdulla Mahzoom Majid, Maryam Shiuna, and Malsha Shareef—over the “derogatory” remarks.

Since then, the Maldivian government and leaders have been trying to diffuse the situation, given the huge number of Indian tourists who flock to the island nation and the economic support from India. Indians topped the list of tourists to the Maldives in 2023. Indians accounted for 11 per cent of the estimated 1.7 million visitors to the Maldives in 2023.

But signs of strain may persist because of Muizzu’s five-day state visit to China. It has raised eyebrows as he chose China for his first state visit. Traditionally, Maldivian presidents have visited India on their first foreign trip. The Maldives has now also asked that New Delhi withdraw its military presence from the archipelago nation before March 15.

Holiday plans apart, a thaw in relations would benefit both countries, but the Maldives more. **BT**

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